

Flaring Emotions, Hot Topics, and Volatile Markets: Modelling the Impacts of the 2025 US Tariffs on Social Media Perspectives and Asset Returns

Research-in-progress

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Abstract

Social media provides a rich lens into how communities respond to disruptive economic and political events, but its unstructured scale creates challenges for conventional research approaches. To address this, Information Systems (IS) scholars have advanced Computationally Intensive Theory Construction, which combines domain knowledge, theory, and computational methods to surface theoretically meaningful patterns. This research-in-progress paper examines the 2025 US tariffs using YouTube videos and comments collected between January and May 2025. Emotions are identified and linked to discussion topics through emotion detection and topic modelling using gpt-4.1-mini and BERTopic, producing two proposed measures: the Emotion Index and the Emotion Polarity Index. These indices will be evaluated using ARX and VARX econometric models to assess their predictive power for asset returns. As work in progress, the study aims to demonstrate the feasibility of combining emotion–topic analysis with financial modelling, contributing to IS theory-building and offering new insights for Behavioural Finance.

Keywords

Computationally Intensive Theory Construction, Econometric Modelling, Emotion Detection, Topic Modelling, Social Media Communities.

1 Introduction

The rise of social media has created new opportunities to study how individuals and communities respond to dramatic economic and political events. Platforms such as YouTube capture rich streams of public discourse, yet their unstructured scale and complexity pose significant challenges for traditional research approaches. To address this, Information Systems (IS) scholars have advanced Computationally Intensive Theory Construction (CITC), a paradigm that combines domain knowledge, theoretical framing, and computational methods to surface patterns with theoretical significance (Berente et al. 2019; Miranda et al. 2022; Yan et al. 2024). This study investigates the 2025 US tariffs between January 1, 2025 and May 31, 2025 through YouTube videos and comments. This event was selected based on IS criteria of novelty, timeliness, and relevance (Benbasat et al. 1987; Myers 2019). The imposition of tariffs offers a unique opportunity to explore these dimensions: the episode was both highly consequential and widely debated, provoking strong emotional and behavioural responses online. It provides a contemporary setting in which to investigate how individuals interpret and react to complex, emotionally charged events through social media. Accordingly, the research question guiding this study is: *How do emotional expressions and alignments in social media discourse during major policy shocks relate to asset price movements?* Although sentiment analysis on social media is well established, studies rarely examine discrete emotions such as fear, anger, or joy that better explain behavioural market responses (Wang et al. 2024). Research on trade policy shocks, including tariff announcements, largely focuses on macroeconomic or firm-level impacts rather than emotional discourse (Trung 2019). Moreover, while financial studies document return and volatility spillovers, the cross-asset transmission of emotional sentiment remains underexplored (Yang et al. 2024). This gap motivates a computational approach linking social media emotions, policy shocks, and asset interconnectedness. This study utilises emotion detection using *gpt-4.1-mini*, topic modelling using BERTopic (Grootendorst 2022) and *gpt-4.1-mini*, and econometric methods such as (vector) autoregressive models with exogenous regressors (Campbell and Thompson 2008; Lütkepohl 2005; Sims 1980). This paper proposes a set of novel indices, the Emotion Index (EI) and the Emotion Polarity Index (EPI), that aim to quantify the emotional expression and alignment of content creators and communities. This index is derived through emotion detection and topic modelling. The predictive power of these indices on asset returns will then be assessed through econometric modelling. The result of the models will validate the utility of the indices and generate useful patterns that can help to illuminate the relationship between social media emotional expression during controversial events and various asset classes such as commodities, equities, and other speculative assets. This research-in-progress paper is structured as follows: we introduce the computational framework used in this research; we then detail the methodology applied; this is followed by the preliminary results, and concludes with the expected contributions and next steps.

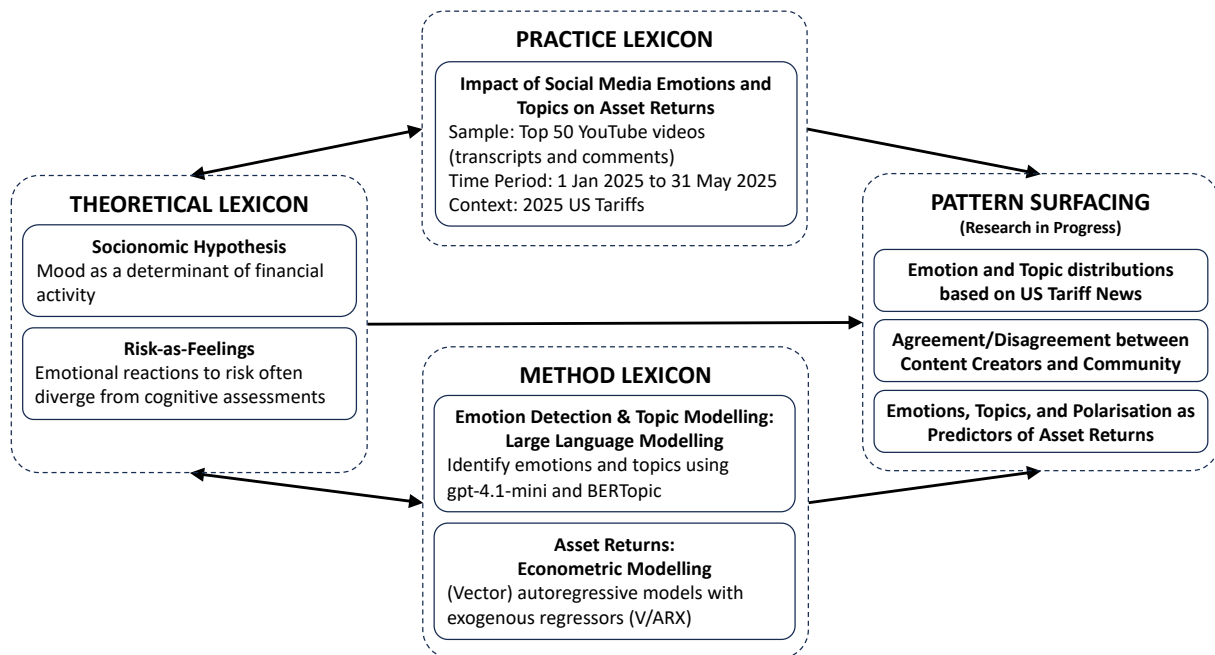


Figure 1. Computational framework for modelling the impact of social media emotion and topics on asset returns.

2 Computationally Intensive Theory Construction for Social Media Emotions and Topics of the 2025 US Tariffs

IS scholars have highlighted the value of CITC to address the distinctive features of research using big data (Berente et al. 2019; Johnson et al. 2019; Lindberg 2020; Miranda et al. 2022). CITC advances theory development through two key mechanisms: lexicon framing (practice, theoretical, and method) and pattern surfacing. The practice lexicon captures the domain-specific knowledge relevant to the empirical setting; the theoretical lexicon articulates the conceptual structures that explain the phenomenon; and the method lexicon outlines the analytic techniques and modelling assumptions employed. Patterns with theoretical significance identified are subsequently articulated in relation to these lexicons to contribute to the theory. Such patterns can provide valuable leverage for inference, enabling inductive generalisation and the formulation of emergent theoretical propositions through abductive reasoning (Lindberg 2020; Miranda et al. 2022; Yan et al. 2024). The computational framework used in this research is illustrated in Figure 1. CITC is particularly suitable for this event because it enables theory-building from complex, high-volume, and multimodal data, such as social media discourse, allowing the discovery of emergent emotional and behavioural patterns that traditional hypothesis-driven methods would struggle to capture amid the volatile, fast-moving context of the 2025 tariffs. The following subsections discuss the framework's lexicons used to computationally generate patterns with theoretical implications during the investigation of the 2025 US Tariffs' impacts.

2.1 Practice Lexicon

This study employs an event-driven, case-based research approach, guided by the established criteria of novelty, timeliness, and relevance in information systems research (Benbasat et al. 1987; Myers 2019). In early 2025, the US implemented a series of sweeping tariffs as part of a protectionist agenda designed to reshape its domestic economy. These trade measures, applied across diverse categories of imports, quickly became a focal point of national and international debate, with social media serving as a key site of public discussion. The first announcement came in February 2025, followed by successive tariff rounds in the ensuing months. Critical milestones in this tariff episode included: the imposition of a 25% levy on Canadian and Mexican imports¹; the declaration of *Liberation Day*, which brought in a blanket 10% tariff on all imports alongside steeper rates (11 to 50%) for selected countries; China's retaliatory duties that escalated into a trade war culminating in a U.S. tariff of 145% on all Chinese goods²; and, finally, a temporary truce reached in May 2025 that suspended further tariff actions. The 2025 measures are broader, harsher, and ultimately more destabilising than the 2018 Trump administration tariffs, which focused primarily on steel and aluminium only. This ignited an intense confrontation between the U.S. and China. These policies not only reshaped patterns of trade and economic performance but also provoked strong emotional and perceptual reactions from the public, shaping discourse and behaviours online. The 2025 tariff saga thus represents a distinctive and timely case for IS research, offering rich opportunities to examine how individuals cope with and interpret emotionally charged, information-heavy events. It enables the examination of how social media users expressed their emotions, debated policies, and sought information during economic upheaval.

2.2 Theoretical Lexicon

A multitude of variables influences the expected returns of assets. These include endogenous variables, variables relating to the assets; and exogenous variables, variables not directly related to the assets. Markets do not always react rationally to changes in endogenous and exogenous variables. In some cases, there may be overreactions to a particular change in the state of the variables. Scholars have also found that investors tend to overreact to the latest information (Grether 1980; Tversky and Kahneman 1974). Research has shown that people tend to overreact to unexpected and dramatic news events (De Bondt and Thaler 1985). The "socioeconomic hypothesis" introduced by Prechter (2002) and elaborated on by Nofsinger (2005) describes how social mood affects the actions undertaken in finance, more specifically, it is the mood that is a determinant of financial activity. The latter's work focuses on the model depicted in suggests that emotions are an input in the cognitive evaluation process, ultimately leading to a decision. Building on this view, Loewenstein et al. (2001) proposed the Risk-as-Feelings perspective, which highlights that emotional reactions to risk often diverge from cognitive assessments. Traditional economic models assume that individuals rationally weigh probabilities and outcomes before acting. In contrast, the Risk-as-Feelings model emphasises that affective responses can emerge more rapidly than deliberative reasoning and, at times, override it. These emotional reactions help

¹ <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/trump-tariffs-mexico-canada-china/>

² <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/coqnd2x1nn3o>

explain why individuals may engage in seemingly irrational behaviours, including panic selling during market downturns or excessive optimism in speculative bubbles (Lerner et al. 2015; Loewenstein et al. 2001). In financial contexts, such mechanisms provide insight into overreactions to events, herd behaviour, and other anomalies that deviate from rational choice theory (Kahneman and Tversky 1979).

2.3 Method Lexicon

Behavioural Finance and IS scholars have long drawn on psychological concepts to study the role of emotions and sentiment in online media. Recent work increasingly uses data from social platforms and applies natural language processing techniques to capture emotional expression in text. Unlike sentiment analysis, which tends to collapse meaning into positive or negative tone, emotion detection provides a more fine-grained view of affective states. Emotion taxonomies such as Plutchik's (1980) opposing pairs and Ekman's (1999) six basic emotions provide the structure for these analyses. Manual annotation of emotions (Farivar et al. 2024) has been a common but resource-intensive strategy, but is now increasingly replaced by generative AI systems that automate labelling and reduce preprocessing. Recent studies also highlight the value of combining emotion detection with topic modelling to link emotional states with underlying themes in online discourse. Newer embedding-based methods like BERTopic (Grootendorst 2022) enable the discovery of topical structures while leveraging pre-trained representations to enhance performance. Integrating these techniques allows researchers to develop a more holistic view of online communities by connecting expressed emotions to the topics that trigger them. This combined approach provides more detailed insights than sentiment or stance detection alone, as it maps both what people are discussing and how they feel about it. In parallel, empirical finance has established a strong tradition of modelling return predictability using autoregressive frameworks. Autoregressive models with exogenous regressors (ARX) are widely applied to capture both the short-run dynamics of asset returns and the incremental influence of external predictors such as macroeconomic conditions or sentiment indices (Campbell and Thompson 2008). Their multivariate counterpart, vector autoregressions with exogenous variables (VARX), extends this approach by modelling interactions across multiple assets or markets while still incorporating external drivers (Lütkepohl 2005; Sims 1980). These frameworks provide a flexible and well-established basis for testing whether novel predictors add explanatory power beyond traditional financial and macroeconomic variables, making them suitable for evaluating measures derived from online emotions and discourse in later stages of analysis. This opens the door to integrating new emotion-based indicators into established econometric models, thereby connecting online behavioural signals with financial return dynamics.

3 Methodology

This section details this research's proposed methodology involving the collection of social media data on the 2025 US Tariffs, emotion detection and topic modelling required to produce indices, the collection of asset prices and related data during the observed period, the modelling of the returns using the indices, and finally the evaluation of the indices and models created.

3.1 2025 US Tariffs Social Media Data Collection

Data were gathered using the YouTube Data API v3, accessed through the APISM package, which enabled asynchronous retrieval of public YouTube transcripts and associated comments concerning the 2025 US tariffs. The collection period spanned from January 1 to May 31, 2025. The search strategy targeted videos addressing the tariffs, their broader consequences, and public responses. The keywords "Trump tariffs" and "US tariffs" were used to query for videos, and on each day of the collection window, the *Search API* was used to capture the 50 most relevant and most viewed uploads. Only videos with available transcripts were retained, with preference to creator-supplied transcripts over auto-generated ones. To preserve inclusivity, no restrictions on language were applied, ensuring a variety of viewpoints. Additional metadata (e.g., number of views, likes, and comments) was retrieved via the *Videos API*, while user comments and their replies were obtained through the *CommentThreads API*.

3.2 Emotion-Topic Indices

Emotions and topics were extracted using a combination of *gpt-4.1-mini* and BERTopic. The use of these models for emotion detection in YouTube discourse is supported by the growing research in this field (Cao et al. 2022; El Azzouzy et al. 2025). Emotion detection was performed on the transcripts and comments using OpenAI's *gpt-4.1-mini*. Structured output generation was utilised with self-healing mechanisms to ensure reliability and type-safety; *gpt-4.1-mini-2025-04-14* was instructed to identify emotions following Plutchik's taxonomy. Initial topics were identified in a similar manner; the initial topic names were unrestricted but limited to 5, allowing for diversity. These topics were embedded using

OpenAI's *text-embedding-3-large* and grouped using BERTopic clustering (Grootendorst 2022) with *gpt-4.1-mini* as the representation model. This combination reduces the risk of hallucinations and improves human readability, especially regarding cluster representations. Each topic has a corresponding emotion. A set of indices has been designed to facilitate the sense-making process and pattern identification from the large dataset. The **Emotion Index (EI)** indicates whether the overall emotions tend to be positive or negative; the EI is calculated for content creators using video transcripts and for the community using the comments. These EIs are then combined into the **Emotion Polarity Index (EPI)**, which measures the level of agreement between the two groups. The indices also have variations that consider the topic related to the emotion analysed. The indices are scaled between -1 and 1. The creator and community EIs are calculated using equation (1) for the content creator or community, equation (2) for topics, and equation (3) for the overall topic-weighted. The topic-weighted EI is particularly important as it gives more weight to the main topic discussed.

$$EI = \frac{\Sigma_{positive} - \Sigma_{negative}}{\Sigma_{positive} + \Sigma_{negative}} \quad (1) \quad EI_{topic} = \frac{\Sigma_{positive,topic} - \Sigma_{negative,topic}}{\Sigma_{positive,topic} + \Sigma_{negative,topic}} \quad (2) \quad EI_{topic-weighted} = \frac{\Sigma_k^m w_k EI_k}{\Sigma_k^m w_k} \quad (3)$$

The EPI scales the creator EI using the community EI to provide a more realistic picture of polarisation; for instance, a video would be deemed more polarising if the emotions expressed by the creator differed from the community. The EPI can be calculated for content creators/community, topics, and topic-weighted by inputting the EIs above into equation (4).

$$EPI = \left(1 - 2 \cdot \left| \frac{EI_{creator} - EI_{community}}{|EI_{creator}| + |EI_{community}| + \epsilon} \right| \right) \cdot \left(1.5 \cdot (|EI_{creator}| + |EI_{community}|)\right) \quad (4)$$

3.3 Asset Prices Data Collection

In parallel with the collection of social media data, daily financial market variables were assembled for the observed period. The dataset includes closing prices for gold, the S&P 500 index, and bitcoin, capturing dynamics in safe-haven assets, equity markets, and cryptocurrencies, respectively. All series were transformed into continuously compounded log-returns defined in equation (5). This standardises units across assets and ensures stationarity in subsequent econometric analyses.

$$r_{i,t} = \ln(P_{i,t}) - \ln(P_{i,t-1}), i \in \{Gold, S\&P, BTC\} \quad (5)$$

To control for broader macroeconomic and market-wide influences, additional variables were incorporated: daily USD/EUR and USD/CNY exchange rates, crude oil spot prices, and the U.S. 10-year Treasury yield. These controls mitigate omitted-variable bias by accounting for exchange-rate fluctuations, energy market shocks, and monetary policy expectations. Frequency alignment was conducted by merging all series at a daily frequency, retaining only trading days common across markets, and applying forward filling where necessary for non-trading-day gaps. This preprocessing ensures a coherent panel structure for subsequent econometric modelling of tariff-related effects.

3.4 Econometric Modelling

Econometric modelling is used to test the predictability of returns with the EPI as an exogenous driver. An Autoregressive with Exogenous Variables (ARX) tests the ability to predict the return of a single asset based on its own past returns, control variables, and the EPI. The return equation is defined as:

$$r_{i,t} = \alpha + \phi r_{i,t-1} + \beta^T [\Delta \ln(USD/EUR_t), \Delta \ln(USD/CNY_t), \Delta \ln(Oil_t), \Delta Yield_t^{10y}]^T + \gamma EPI_{t-n} + \varepsilon_t \quad (6)$$

A Vector Autoregression with Exogenous Variables (VARX) will subsequently model all three assets (gold, S&P, and bitcoin) together, since they may influence each other. The model allows spillovers, such as past S&P return, potentially influencing today's Bitcoin return. The return equation is defined as:

$$\begin{bmatrix} r_{Gold,t} \\ r_{S\&P,t} \\ r_{BTC,t} \end{bmatrix} = c + A_1 r_{t-1} + B x_t + \gamma EPI_{t-n} + \varepsilon_t \quad (7)$$

The EPI is incorporated into ARX and VARX models using its lagged values to provide a valid predictive test. This lag structure mitigates simultaneity concerns, since the same event may influence both market returns and the EPI contemporaneously. Different lag lengths (one, two, three, and five days) are examined to evaluate whether polarisation effects persist over time.

3.5 Evaluation

The predictive role of the EPI is evaluated through hypothesis testing, where the null hypothesis specifies no incremental predictive content ($H_0: \gamma = 0$) and the alternative hypothesis posits that the EPI

significantly explains asset returns. In ARX models, significance is assessed using t-statistics, whereas in VARX models, joint restrictions are tested using Wald or likelihood ratio procedures. To guard against spurious inference, a set of control variables is incorporated to capture global macroeconomic and financial conditions. Finally, the analysis extends beyond in-sample estimation to examine out-of-sample predictive performance, contrasting models with and without the EPI. Forecast accuracy is assessed using Mean Squared Error (MSE), Mean Absolute Error (MAE), the out-of-sample R^2 , and Diebold-Mariano tests, determining whether the EPI provides practical forecasting improvements.

4 Preliminary Results

The Creator and Community EIs, and the EPI calculated for the period observed, show promising results. The 7-day moving average of the indices, displayed in Figure 2, aligns with the key events of the 2025 US Tariffs saga. News related to announcements and the imposition of tariffs trigger peaks in the EPI, indicating lesser polarisation between content creators and community members during these periods compared to non-critical periods. Their emotions appear to diverge during those times. The EIs support these results: content creators appear to be more emotionally volatile and more positive compared to community members. This may potentially be due to their tendency to sensationalise news to generate more views (Shevtsov et al. 2023).

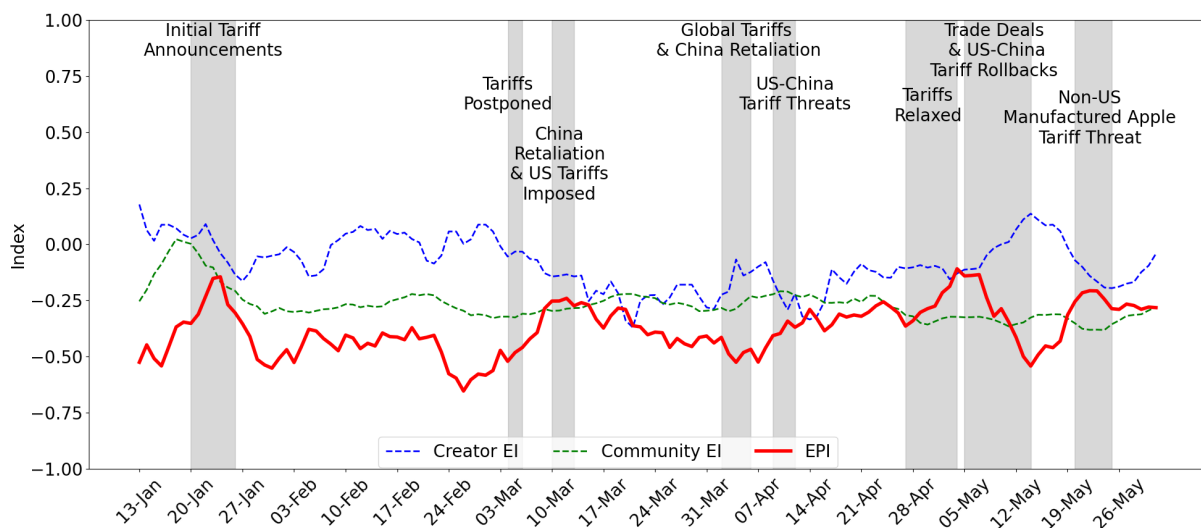


Figure 2. Emotion Polarity Indices of the 2025 US Tariffs YouTube videos and comments (7-day moving average).

The average EPI ± 2 days from the news was found to be -0.31 compared to the average of -0.42 during non-key periods. This difference has been found to be different from the baseline EPI at a 10% significance level, further supporting the pattern of emotional alignment in times of turmoil.

5 Expected Contribution and Next Steps

Our preliminary results suggest potential patterns with theoretical implications regarding the emotional expression of content creators and community members during the 2025 US tariffs saga. The lesser polarisation observed during these periods compared to the more volatile emotional expression of the content creators suggests that their apparent sensationalisation of events could be aligned with the community's emotional state. This pattern will be examined in further detail through the calculation of topic-weighted EIs and EPI. The inclusion of topics in the indices will help to illuminate the context of the emotional expression observed. Econometric models will also be developed to quantify the predictive power of the indices created. This will aid in observing patterns relating to the emotional reaction of investors to the tariff news and its impact on various asset classes such as commodities (gold), equities (S&P500), and speculative assets (bitcoin). The models will also serve to validate the indices proposed, through the assessment of their predictive power and their utility in financial decision-making. These contributions are expected to further our understanding of the emotional climate resulting from the 2025 US tariffs, their impacts on content creation, online community discourse, and on various asset classes. The patterns surfacing from the analysis of the indices and the econometric models will contribute to the fields of Behavioural Finance and IS.

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